

Adoption



A judge speaks from the bench, glad. A family gathers a child in — father, mother, son — faces up, unashamed. The law and the hug are both in the frame.

Before you gather

- Read Day 23, Adoption, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Galatians 4:4–7 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.

- Leave with a name. The missional challenge only works if someone is named before you pray.

1 · ICEBREAKER · 7 MIN

Open the room

What is a place you did not start out belonging, where someone eventually made a place for you?

Leader. Being brought in. The book already asked about belonging, church conflict, and loneliness. Stay out of those three prompts. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 · THE WORD · 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: Adoption is not God pretending you were always fine. It is a legal welcome into His family, through Jesus, because He wanted you. Rights, a name, an inheritance, and a Father who is glad.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Adoption means God welcomes believers into His family as dear children, giving us full rights and love as heirs in Christ.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek huiothesia — placement as a son, the legal act of adoption.

MEMORY VERSE · EPHESIANS 1:4–5

In love he predestined us for adoption to himself as sons through Jesus Christ, according to the purpose of his will.

Together, open the flashcard for Adoption. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

3 · OPEN THE BIBLE · 15 MIN

Galatians 4:4–7

Paul moves a person from slave to son to heir, and puts “Abba, Father” in their mouth. That is the doctrine in one paragraph, and it is not the journal assignment.

But when the fullness of time had come, God sent forth his Son, born of woman, born under the law, to redeem those who were under the law, so that we might receive adoption as sons. And because you are sons, God has sent the Spirit of his Son into our hearts, crying, “Abba! Father!” So you are no longer a slave, but a son, and if a son, then an heir through God.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. Trace the sequence: what did the Son do, what do we receive, and what does the Spirit cry? **CORE**

Leader. Born under the law, He redeems. We receive adoption. The Spirit cries Abba. Sonship is not a mood. It follows redemption and comes with the Spirit.

2. What is the difference, in verse 7, between a slave in the house and a son?

Leader. A slave may work on the property. A son inherits it. Duty without adoption is not the gospel.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. Romans 8:15–17 says the Spirit does not lead us back into fear, and that children are heirs — heirs with Christ, provided we suffer with Him. How does adoption speak to fear, and why does Paul refuse to separate sonship from sharing Christ’s sufferings?

CORE

Leader. Abba answers fear. Glory later includes suffering now. Adoption is not a promise that the family avoids pain. It is a promise you do not face it as an orphan.

4. Ephesians 1:5 says this was “according to the purpose of his will,” in love. What happens to assurance if we think we were adopted because we were the promising kid?

Leader. The purpose was His. The love was His. Promising kids burn out trying to stay adoptable.

5. John 1:12–13: he gave the right to become children of God to those who received Him, born not of the will of the flesh. Who in your actual life still thinks they have to earn a seat at a father’s table — maybe even yours?

Leader. A child, a friend, a new believer. Ask what a word of welcome would sound like that does not add a condition Christ did not add.

5 · SAY IT · 5 MIN

In one sentence

Adoption means God receives believers as His own children and heirs, through Jesus, because He loves them.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 · THIS WEEK · 5 MIN

Missional challenge

Before next week, carry this word to someone far from Jesus — a neighbor, a classmate, a coworker, a friend. Do it with a real action and with a true sentence. Name the person before you pray.

Make room at a table for someone who does not belong anywhere obvious. Save the seat before they earn it. Tell them adoption means God receives people as His children through Jesus, not after they clean themselves up.

Leader. One meal is enough. Welcome them. Do not turn them into a project. Next week, before the icebreaker, take one minute. Who went, and what happened? One sentence. No speeches.

7 • PRAY • 8 MIN

Leave silence between these

1. Pray the word Abba slowly. Let it be awkward if it is awkward.
2. Thank Him that you are not staff in the house.
3. Pray for someone who only knows fathers as fear.

Before you stumble

The courtroom drawing can hurt someone whose adoption or family story is complicated. Say at the outset: this doctrine does not depend on your earthly parents being a good parable. God is the Father Jesus trusted, not a magnification of a wound. “Sons” in Galatians 4 is legal status for every believer, women and men. Daughters are not second-tier. The word is about the rights of the heir. Say so. Do not force anyone to share a family story.

WITH STUDENTS

Ask what a last name does at school, on a jersey, on a form. Then ask what it would mean that God put His name on them before they performed.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Luke 15:22–24, the robe, the ring, and the feast. You used the embrace in week 2. Here, notice the signs of sonship restored. Two minutes, if you want a picture.